Co-Designing Parkinson's Care: Hybrid Open House Outcomes

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Introduction

Parkinson's disease (PD) is a progressive neurodegenerative condition that affects motor function, cognition, and daily life for individuals with PD and their care partners (Gopala Krishna Pillai et al., 2023; Hellqvist et al., 2020). Educational and self-management programs are a key component of comprehensive PD care, improving disease-specific knowledge, self-management skills, and aspects of quality of life (A'Campo et al., 2010; Hellqvist et al., 2020). Evidence also suggests that structured education for caregivers and health professionals can increase PD knowledge, confidence, and perceived ability to provide effective support (A'Campo et al., 2010; Gopala Krishna Pillai et al., 2023).

Structured education and self-management programs for people with PD have been shown to improve disease-specific knowledge, enhance self-management skills, and support better quality of life (Hellqvist et al., 2020; Gopala Krishna Pillai et al., 2023). For example, PD self-management courses and community programs that combine education with exercise and psychosocial support are associated with perceived improvements in mobility, daily functioning, and emotional well-being (A'Campo et al., 2010; Hellqvist et al., 2020). Parallel work in care settings indicates that PD-specific training for health and social care staff increases knowledge and confidence, can improve care practices, and may reduce adverse outcomes such as medication errors or preventable complications (Gopala Krishna Pillai et al., 2023). Caregiver-focused education likewise appears to reduce burden and improve caregivers' perception of their ability to support the person with PD, underscoring education as a shared need across stakeholders (A'Campo et al., 2010; Sepp et al., 2023).

Despite this emerging evidence, less is known about how different groups involved in PD care perceive community-based education events that are outside traditional clinical encounters (Gopala Krishna Pillai et al., 2023). Understanding how individuals experience and value such events can inform the design of future programs that are responsive to diverse informational needs, preferences, and barriers. The purpose of this project is to:

- Describe perceptions of a PD-focused community education event among people living with PD, their caregivers, and professionals who work with PD
- Identify perceived benefits, unmet needs, and priorities to guide future community education initiatives

Method

Participants

Approximately 50 individuals attended the event. For the pre-event survey, thirteen individuals with PD, seven care partners, and five professionals responded to the questionnaire. For the post-event survey, eleven individuals with PD, four care partners, and three professionals responded to the questionnaire.

Participants were recruited from the Tempe community, previous ASU Speech and Hearing Clinic clients, and community partners.

Procedure

Seven (7) Interactive Stations

Station Types: 1. Overview of PD, Consent to Research, Pre-Event Survey. 2. PD and Communication. 3. PD and Swallowing. 4. PD and Cognition. 5. PD: Movement and Balance. 6. PD: Mental Health and Counseling. 7. PD: Resources and Future Directions; Post-event Survey.

Hybrid attendance: in-person at the ASU Tempe campus clinic and live via Zoom. Student-faculty teams co-led content areas and participant interactions.

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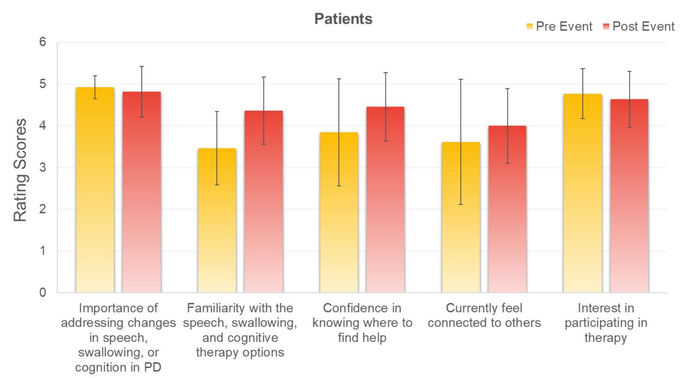
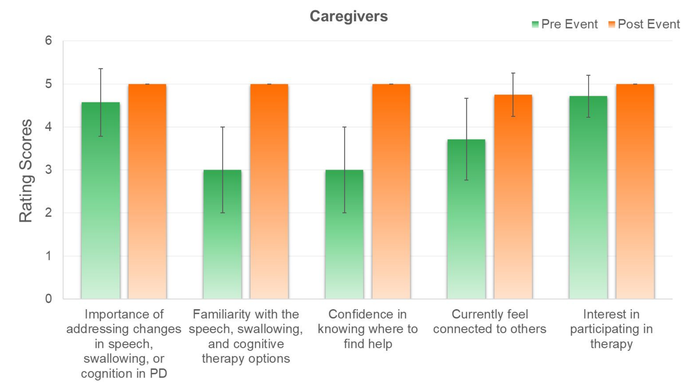
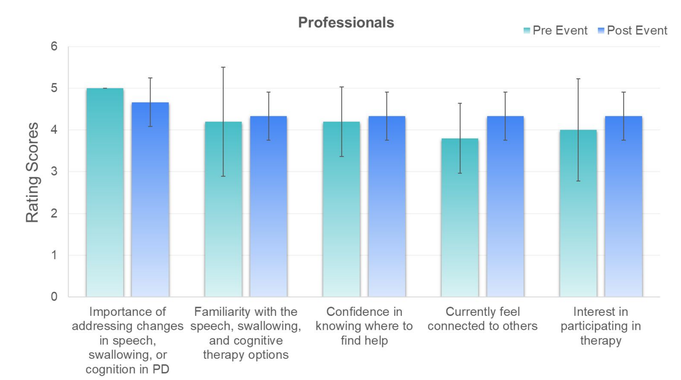
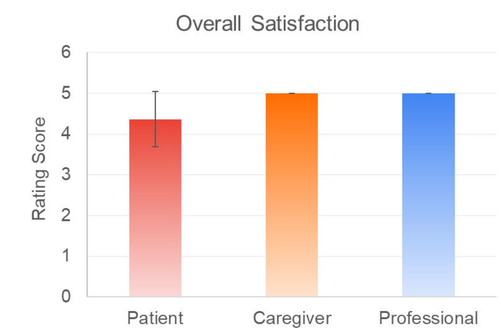
Results









Conclusions

Across all stakeholder groups, the open house appeared to meet its primary goals of increasing knowledge about PD-related communication, swallowing, and cognitive resources and strengthening connections to available services. Pre- to post-event trends suggested gains in familiarity with therapy options and where to find help, particularly among people with PD and care partners. Given that professionals are familiar with topics and resources, it is unsurprising that their ratings remained stable from pre- to post-event.

Open-ended comments highlighted appreciation for concrete information, opportunities to "meet others" affected by PD and "get to know people," and exposure to specific programs (for example, SPEAK OUT! and group offerings), indicating that attendees valued both educational content and the sense of community fostered by the event. Healthcare professionals emphasized gaining resources for their patients and supporting faculty efforts, suggesting the format also functioned as a bridge between community members and providers. Together, these findings support the feasibility and perceived usefulness of a community-based education event as a strategy to enhance PD-specific knowledge, resource awareness, and social connection among people with PD, their care partners, and professionals.

References

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